



GOV. COMM. 24-182
(HOUSE)

David M. Apatang
Governor

Dennis James C. Mendiola
Lieutenant Governor

COMMONWEALTH OF THE NORTHERN MARIANA ISLANDS
OFFICE OF THE GOVERNOR

August 27, 2026

GOV2026-546

The Honorable Edmund S. Villagomez
Speaker
House of Representatives
Twenty-Fourth Northern Marianas
Commonwealth Legislature
Saipan, MP 96950

The Honorable Karl R. King-Nabors
President
The Senate; Twenty-Fourth Northern
Marianas Commonwealth Legislature
Saipan, MP 96950

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JD 8/28/26

Dear Mr. Speaker and Mr. President:

This is to inform you that I have signed into law **House Bill No. 24-10**, entitled, "To establish a change of name legal procedure in the CNMI.", which was passed by the House of Representatives and the Senate of the Twenty-Fourth Northern Marianas Commonwealth Legislature.

This bill becomes **Public Law No. 24-38**. Copies bearing my signature are forwarded for your reference.

Sincerely,


DAVID M. APATANG
Governor

cc: Lieutenant Governor; Attorney General; Commonwealth Law Revision Commission;
Public Auditor; CNMI Judiciary; Acting Special Assistant for Administration;
Programs and Legislative Review



**TWENTY-FOURTH NORTHERN MARIANA COMMONWEALTH LEGISLATURE
IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES**

FIRST REGULAR SESSION

MARCH 11, 2025

REPRESENTATIVE JOEL C. CAMACHO OF SAIPAN, PRECINCT 4 (*for himself*, Representatives Blas Jonathan "BJ" T. Attao, Julie M. A. Ogo, Edmund S. Villagomez and Ralph N. Yumul) in an open and public meeting with an opportunity for the public to comment, introduced the following Bill:

**H. B. No. 24-10
AN ACT**

**TO ESTABLISH A CHANGE OF NAME LEGAL PROCEDURE
IN THE CNMI.**

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

The Bill was referred to the House Committee on Judiciary and Governmental Operations, which submitted Standing Committee Report 24-24; adopted 8/29/2026.

**THE BILL WAS PASSED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES ON
FIRST AND FINAL READING, AUGUST 29, 2025;**
without amendments and transmitted to **THE SENATE.**

IN THE SENATE

The Bill was referred to the Senate Committee on Judiciary, Government, and Law, which submitted Standing Committee Report 24-82; adopted 8/14/2026.

THE BILL WAS PASSED BY THE SENATE ON FIRST AND FINAL READING, AUGUST 14, 2026;
without amendments and returned to **THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES.**

**H. B. NO. 24-10 IS DULY PASSED BY THE TWENTY-FOURTH NORTHERN MARIANAS COMMONWEALTH
LEGISLATURE.**



Linda B. Muña, House Clerk



TWENTY-FOURTH NORTHERN MARIANAS COMMONWEALTH LEGISLATURE
IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

SECOND DAY, SECOND REGULAR SESSION

AUGUST 29, 2025

H. B. No. 24-10

AN ACT

**TO ESTABLISH A CHANGE OF NAME LEGAL PROCEDURE IN THE
CNMI.**

**BE IT ENACTED BY THE TWENTY-FOURTH NORTHERN
MARIANAS COMMONWEALTH LEGISLATURE:**

1 **SECTION 1. FINDINGS AND PURPOSE.**

2 The Legislature finds that the CNMI currently lacks a standardized
3 procedure for legally changing a person's name. While the Commonwealth Code
4 provides a name change procedure within the context of adoption and grants the
5 Commonwealth's Registrar of Vital Statistics the authority to amend a birth
6 certificate upon receipt of a certified court order for a name change, the Code
7 does not establish a general process applicable to adults seeking a legal name
8 change outside of these circumstances.

9 The absence of a general name change procedure has led to uncertainty for
10 residents seeking to change their names for legitimate personal, cultural, or
11 professional reasons. The Legislature recognizes that other jurisdictions provide
12 straightforward and transparent legal mechanisms for individuals to petition
13 the court for a name change, ensuring due process while preventing fraud and
14 misuse.

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1 To address this gap, this Act establishes a legal procedure for name changes
2 in the CNMI. The process balances the petitioner's right to a name change with
3 safeguards to prevent fraudulent or unlawful name changes. This Act also
4 ensures that court-approved name changes are legally recognized for purposes
5 of updating government-issued identification and official records. By enacting
6 this legislation, the Commonwealth strengthens access to legal name changes
7 while maintaining judicial oversight and procedural safeguards to protect public
8 and private interests.

9 Thus, the purpose of this Act is to establish a change of name legal procedure
10 in the CNMI.

11 **SECTION 2. ENACTMENT.**

12 There is hereby enacted a new Chapter 12 within Title 8, Division 1 of the
13 Commonwealth Code to read as follows:

14 **"Chapter 12. Change of Name**

15 **§ 101. Change of Name Petition**

16 (a) Any CNMI resident who wishes to obtain an official court-
17 recognized name change may file a petition with the CNMI Superior Court.

18 (b) The petition shall be in writing, signed by the petitioner, and shall
19 include the following:

20 (1) The petitioner's current legal name, date of birth, place of
21 birth, and residence;

22 (2) The name the petitioner proposes to assume; and

23 (3) A declaration, made under penalty of perjury, that the
24 petitioner is not seeking the name change for any fraudulent or
25 unlawful purpose, to mislead or deceive others, to evade legal
26 obligations, or to interfere with the rights of others.

27 (c) The CNMI Supreme Court may establish standard petition forms
28 and set a reasonable filing fee for change of name petitions. A petitioner who
29 is indigent may request a fee waiver.

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§ 102. Public Notice Requirement

(a) Unless waived by the court for good cause, a petitioner must publish a notice of the proposed name change at least twice in a newspaper of general circulation in the CNMI. The publications must occur at least 7 days apart. The first publication shall be made at least 30 days before the hearing on the change of name of petition, and the second publication shall be made at least 14 days before the hearing. The notice shall include the following:

(1) The petitioner's current legal name;

(2) The name the petitioner proposes to assume;

(3) A statement that the petition has been filed with the CNMI Superior Court, including the case number, if applicable;

(4) The date, time, and location of the scheduled hearing on the change of name petition;

(5) A statement that any person may file an objection with the court before the scheduled hearing if they believe the name change is being sought for any fraudulent or unlawful purpose, to mislead or deceive others, to evade legal obligations, or to interfere with the rights of others; and

(6) Instructions on where and how to submit objections, including the address of the CNMI Superior Court and the deadline for filing.

(b) The petitioner shall file proof of publication with the court prior to the scheduled hearing date. Failure to provide proof of publication may result in dismissal of the petition. The court may waive this proof of publication requirement for good cause.

(c) Any person with an objection to the change of name petition may file a written opposition with the court before the scheduled hearing.

§ 103. Judicial Review and Hearing

(a) The court shall conduct a hearing on the change of name petition and consider whether the name is being sought for any fraudulent or unlawful purpose, to mislead or deceive others, to evade legal obligations, or to interfere with the rights of others.

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1 (b) The discretion of a CNMI Superior Court judge over a change of
2 name petition shall be exercised on the basis of evidence and not conclusory
3 assertions. The court shall not deny a change of name petition based solely
4 on speculative or subjective concerns.

5 (c) The court shall grant the change of name petition if no substantial
6 evidence exists that the name change is sought for any fraudulent or
7 unlawful purpose, to mislead or deceive others, to evade legal obligations, or
8 to interfere with the rights of others.

9 **§ 104. Court Order and Legal Effect**

10 (a) If the court grants a change of name petition, it shall issue an order
11 officially recognizing the new name.

12 (b) The petitioner may use the court order to update their legal
13 documents, including identification cards, birth certificates, and other
14 official records.

15 (c) An order granting a change of name petition is a final judgment
16 subject to appeal; provided, such appeal is made to the CNMI Supreme
17 Court within 30 days of its issuance.”

18 **SECTION 3. SEVERABILITY.**

19 If any provisions of this Act or the application of any such provision to any
20 person or circumstance should be held invalid by a court of competent
21 jurisdiction, the remainder of this Act or the application of its provisions to
22 persons or circumstances other than those to which it is held invalid shall not
23 be affected thereby.

24 **SECTION 4. SAVINGS CLAUSE.**

25 This Act and any repealer contained herein shall not be construed as
26 affecting any existing right acquired under contract or acquired under statutes
27 repealed or under any rule, regulation, or order adopted under the statutes.
28 Repealers contained in this Act shall not affect any proceeding instituted under
29 or pursuant to prior law. The enactment of the Act shall not have the effect of
30 terminating, or in any way modifying, any liability, civil or criminal, which shall
31 already be in existence on the date this Act becomes effective.

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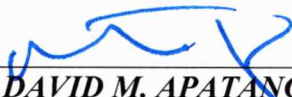
SECTION 5. EFFECTIVE DATE.

This Act shall take effect upon its approval by the Governor, or it becoming law without such approval.

Attested to by: 
Linda B. Muña, House Clerk

Certified by: 
SPEAKER EDMUND S. VILLAGOMEZ
House of Representatives
24th Northern Marianas Commonwealth Legislature

Approved this 27th day of August, 2026


DAVID M. APATANG
Governor
Commonwealth of the Northern Mariana Islands